

Miners, ASU Start WAC Season

The University of Texas at El Paso and Arizona State University kick off Western Athletic Conference Southern Division baseball action 2 p.m. Friday, as the Miners host the Sun Devils at Dudley Field for a three-game series.

ASU (25-13) is fresh from a sweep of the West Coast where it finished 9-4, winning the University of California Riverside Baseball Tournament by downing UCLA 5-0, then Stanford for the championship 6-3.

The Sun Devils also split with defending national champ Southern Cal.

U.T. El Paso rode a 10-game win skein until last week for a school record, then lost it when New York City's Baruch College bounced back after three straight losses to the Miners to win the finale 7-4.

Percentage-wise, the Miners are second in the WAC-South to league-leading Arizona .952-.692 with ASU next at .657 and New Mexico with .607. The Wildcats have a 40-2 season record, U.T. El Paso 18-8.

Roy Stringer (4-0), who set a school team record in strikeouts at 15 last week, will start for Coach Andy Cohen. This should be a plus for the Miners in that ASU has yet to see Stringer perform. Last week

when they tried to scout the U.T. El Paso-NMSU contest all they saw was dust, the games postponed due to bad weather.

Coach Jim Brock, who says there is always pressure when playing in El Paso against the Miners, will start sophomore John Poloni (5-0) who in seven appearances has stuck out 35 and has a 2.90 earned run average compared to 2.80 for Stringer.

On the ready for Saturday's 1 p.m., doubleheader will be Jim Umbarger (4-1), a junior, and Jim Peterson (7-0), a freshman who sports a 1.97 ERA in 10 outings and a shutout to his credit.

Over the years ASU has lost only four contests to the Miners, the last coming in 1971, a 5-4 decision. In their 33 wins over U.T. El Paso the Sun Devils posted six of them last season.

Bump Wills, coming off a .467 clip at Riverside's tourney, is currently leading the Tempe, Ariz., hitters with a .388 average from 38 games including eight home runs. He's accounted for 34 RBI's off 55 hits and scored 47 runs. Wills collected six homers alone in the recent west coast drive. He also tied a tourney record with

five stolen bases and scored 14 runs for another which earned him Most Valuable Player honors.

U.T. El Paso's third baseman Glenn Villarreal tops the Miners in team hitting with .400 and has scored 24 runs off 34 hits, driving in 18 mates.

Catcher Jim Brundage follows with .385, center fielder Joe Pennies has .378, left fielder Herb Von Hagen .369 and second baseman Mark Miller has .358.

Although ASU's hitting has come through lately and their speed has come up with some extra bases.

"If we can come through with some consistent mound work, we'll be a good ball club," Doug Gerlach, Assistant Sports Information Director said Thursday upon arrival in The Sun City. "We got off to a slow start but the hitting is starting to come around and we're showing team speed."

"But Andy Cohen has always done something in the past that has made it tough," he added.

Cohen says his Miners are ready for them (ASU) and if they don't make a good showing it's all their own (Miner's) fault.